

fast FORWARD

Ishant Sharma, Man of the Series against Australia, is the most exciting young fast bowler in the game, the tankful of oxygen India need to make their assault on the summit of world cricket



AP PHOTO

| By Sharda Ugra |

Surely this qualifies as breaking news: there's a fellow in Delhi who claims to be Ishant Sharma's hair stylist and what's more, the disarray that resides atop the cricketer's head is, in fact, a haircut. Fortunately, for his team, Sharma is more than just the sum of his appearance, which falls somewhere between disappointed *Indian Idol* contestant and a dishevelled giraffe. He is a 20-year-old whose progress over the last year has given India's bowling attack sting and muscle. He is also the first Indian fast bowler to be named a Man of the Series at home since Kapil Dev in 1983. He is now widely

Sharma finished the series with 15 wickets, the Man of the Series trophy, a brand new Toyota, a Rs 1.7-lakh wristwatch from Shah Rukh Khan and a shiny, new reputation. Not bad for a 6 ft 4 inch youth from west Delhi whose short 13-Test, 17-ODI career for India (60 wickets @32.09) has mostly been played out at double speed.

It is a rare young cricketer who

runs into the toughest team in the world twice inside a year and instead of being flattened by the impact, flicks them off like specks of dust on his whites. On wickets that have mostly been chaise lounges for batsmen, Sharma, stiltwalker limbs and flying mane, has come tearing in. Be it 9.36 a.m. (he never bowls the first over because it's a personal jinx) or 4 p.m., his

ISHANT SHARMA (LEFT); TEAM INDIA CELEBRATES AFTER WINNING THE BORDER-GAVASKAR TROPHY IN NAGPUR

thought of as the tankful of oxygen India need to make a concerted assault on the very summit of world cricket—the No.1 ranking. It can dream of doing so as Sharma and his older pace partner Zaheer Khan made the hostile first inroads for India's recent 2-0 Border-Gavaskar Trophy victory over the once-formidable Australians.